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RCAH 292B/395

4 July 2013

Santa Rosa-Cartagena: Women's Opportunities in Leadership and Solidarity

Above: Señora Quirós earns her living partly by sewing handmade clothing in her home. She attended an institute to learn skilled craftsmanship and thinks a women's artisan cooperative would be a good thing for the community.

Part A: Existing Projects and Current Challenges

In Santa Rosa-Cartagena, I studied associations providing opportunities for women to take leadership positions and to build solidarity amongst each other, through the lens of women's issues as a whole. I asked about the structure and function of these projects, as well as important issues and challenges in the women's lives. For a small population of about one hundred families in Santa Rosa and about twelve families in Cartagena (L. Madden, personal communication, June 1, 2013), the community seems well organized with many committees.

Asociación ANDAR, which conducts many projects including some in Guatemala and Honduras, was formed in October 1989. The Eco-Finca, an organic farm in Cartagena with which we worked directly through ANDAR, began in 1998, in order to improve the quality of life for rural families, in particular households headed by women; it is owned by Lidiethe Madden. Visitors from Michigan State University have worked with the Eco-Finca for ten years. One of its important goals is to build community capacity (L. Madden, personal communication, June 1, 2013). Other important functions of the Eco-Finca are to conserve nature, protect water and forest resources, and provide food security (Asociación Andar). Its principles include gender equity and equality of opportunity, as well as using natural resources in a sustainable way. Some services offered by ANDAR to farming families include training activities, credit, technical assistance and marketing, in order to promote sustainable development. It has a total area of 15 hectares, with 1.7 hectares dedicated to organic agriculture and medicinal plants, and 11 hectares of protected primary and secondary forest, including trails (Asociación Andar).

Currently, however, the Eco-Finca appears somewhat disconnected from the community. Because ANDAR has less funding with which to pay workers, fewer community members work there now than in the past. Work on the Eco-Finca is occasional, relying on the presence of tourists. Except for two employees who work quarter-time and one hour daily respectively, community members are not hired at the Eco-Finca when tourists are not present (J. Quirós, personal communication, June 20, 2013). As well, the Eco-Finca does not sell its food here in Santa Rosa because residents prefer to buy groceries in Guápiles or Cariari; organic vegetables from the Eco-Finca cost more (N. Sandí, personal communication, June 11, 2013).

A new agricultural co-op was recently started by community members: “Asociación Pro-mujeres Cultivando la Naturaleza: CUNA”. Its visitors’ book states that CUNA developed out of

necessity due to problems of work, health and security for families and especially for women, and to stop small agricultural producers from disappearing among *monocultivos,* larger plantations that grow one single crop. The co-op hopes to resolve problems collectively, to keep the environment and the soil rich for the future, to produce abundant and healthy food, and to avoid rural migration (COOPECUNA "Libro de Visitantes"). Its motto is "Health, Education, Work." Right now, out of the associations I explored, CUNA seems to me to have the richest opportunities for women on the largest scale. One opportunity mentioned was to "compartir con las companeras," or to share with companions. Others included working and earning money, learning more about nature, agriculture, and tourism, and having better health due to exercise and eating food grown without chemicals (CUNA, community discussion, June 22, 2013). We had a very spirited discussion with members of the co-op regarding hopes for its future, while making tamales for one of its fundraisers.

CUNA's official date of foundation, in the public registry at San José, is October 27th, 2011 (J. Quirós, personal communication, June 22, 2013). Members are currently 23 families who all participate equally in farm work and all contribute dues; the central farm, collectively owned, surrounds Don Julio's house, with other small farms spread out, some in other towns. The co-op is organized in several different committees, but important decisions are made by majority vote at general meetings of all members, so everyone knows what is going on. CUNA wants to attract more tourists, as well as international volunteers (G. Mora, personal communication, June 11, 2013); other current priorities include expanding its number of cacao plants, receiving certification from the Instituto Costarricense de Turismo (ICT), and acquiring a small tractor. Mora mentioned that CUNA is a supportive group that shares many things, including meals and produce from the farm. Among other things, CUNA grows cacao,

pineapple, yucca, plantains and bananas, papayas, tomatoes, and cilantro (G. Mora, personal communication, June 24, 2013).

Interesting viewpoints were raised concerning CUNA's designation as "pro-mujeres" or pro-women. Guisselle Mora, its president, displayed a belief in traditional gender roles, describing the existence of a masculine hand and a feminine hand, where each alone would lack the other. Her reasoning for including both genders in CUNA was that men can do certain kinds of farm work that women cannot, and that women can do certain kinds of work that men cannot (G. Mora, personal communication, June 22, 2013). Don Julio, the *gerente* (manager), said that women look at land differently from men – seeing it as a place to grow food, rather than wanting to sell the land for money (J. Quirós, personal communication, June 11, 2013).

The Santa Rosa school, currently with 56 students, has two associations: the Junta de Educación (school board), and Patronato Escolar (board of trustees.) All current members of the two boards are women. The job of the Junta de Educación is to take care of the school's economic responsibilities and seek out sources of aid. At the end of each year, the board calculates the school's expenses for the next year, a difficult process that includes the monthly costs of light, water, electricity, phone service, cafeteria food and the cook. It also completes *alicitaciones* to buy school supplies, such as paper, pens and pencils, searching for the best price and quality between the department stores and bookstores in Cariari and Guápiles. The school is currently seeking aid to construct a new cafeteria, and to build a computer lab, which would bring more access to educational information. Campós mentioned that the board must "knock on many doors" since the government does not always respond to the school's needs. Also, the sixth graders at the Santa Rosa school are currently creating a school library.

The Junta Parroquial of the Catholic Church has existed for about thirty years, since the current church building was constructed with help from the community. The board manages money for the church, arranges religious courses for baptism, first communion, confirmation and matrimony, and asks for donations of food and clothing for those in need. It would like to involve more new people, including youth. A member described the board's mission as serving God and the community in all possible ways, including spiritual help and perseverance. She said it is important to have dialogue, and that the church is an important place for women here to talk. (O. Agüero, personal communication, June 23, 2013).

Finding employment is a key challenge for women; this issue was raised in every single interview. Many women here are without spouses, either unmarried, widowed, or divorced. It is very difficult for women to find work here: the little available includes field work on plantations or family farms, cleaning houses, sewing, or raising animals such as pigs or milk cows, as well as providing homestays when tourists visit town. Sometimes women must go to another town such as Guápiles to find work. Although some women are employed at pineapple or banana plantations, the work is very hard and the plantations discriminate against them, by hiring women less willingly and paying them less than men (L. Madden, personal communication, June 25, 2013). Many young people leave the community after high school because of the difficulty finding employment in Santa Rosa (S. Quirós, personal communication, June 10, 2013).

The challenge of finding access to higher education, which leads to increased opportunities, came up across many interviews. For students who make the daily hour-long bus trip to Guapilés, there is a unique technical high school, the Colegio Técnico Profesional de Pococí, which offers professional programs such as tourism, information technology, and *agropecuaria* (crops and cattle). Getting to university is a challenge for youth, due to passing the

high school diploma and university entrance exams, and paying for housing and living costs, even though the cost of tuition itself is low at public universities (S. Quirós, personal communication, June 10, 2013). Illiteracy is present among some adults in the community, and many adults have not attended high school.

Other issues of concern, each raised in at least several interviews, included economic challenges and the cycle of poverty, women living *sola* (alone), domestic violence, and chemical pollution from pineapple and banana plantations, which can contaminate the water and cause health problems. Lidiethe Madden stated that there is a high divorce rate among women in Costa Rica, and cycles of domestic violence and *machismo* (male chauvinism) are a common problem (L. Madden, personal communication, June 1, 2013). We know that at least one woman in the community has a history of domestic violence, and at least one child is abused at home. When I asked one woman directly whether she thought domestic violence was a problem here, she replied that she thought it was a problem but did not personally know anyone experiencing it, and that emotional rather than physical aggression may be more widespread (Y. Pereira, personal communication, June 22, 2013).

Part B: Impacts of Agro Ecotourism and Homestay Tourism on the Community

For homestay families that house Eco-Finca volunteers, economic impacts are beneficial and significant. However, these benefits are concentrated upon the individual homestay families rather than distributed throughout the community as a whole. From the amount our group of students paid ANDAR, $20 per guest per night goes to each homestay family, including lodging and three meals. Each of us also paid for someone in our host family to work for 40 hours at the Eco-Finca (40 mil colones, at 1 mil per hour) during the time we were volunteering (L. Madden,

personal communication, June 26, 2013). This relates to the point in Koens' "Ecotourism as a Development Strategy" that "women have gained empowerment" (Koens 1231) through ecotourism, because having their own source of income is empowering to the women in Santa Rosa. In the table, this falls under the benefit of "empowerment of deprived groups"(Koens 1227). Since unemployment is a severe problem in Santa Rosa, homestay tourism is a welcome opportunity to earn money. However, work on the Eco-Finca is occasional, only available to others besides Don Julio and Dona Nely when tourists are present. When tourists are not present, Don Julio works 25% of full time and Dona Nely works 1 hour per day, but for other community members the Eco-Finca is not a stable source of employment (J. Quirós, personal communication, June 20, 2013). The issue of unsteady employment relates to a point in Bernardo Trejos' article that "…there is no evidence that support networks would solve the problem of low employment and income, which is typical of rural tourism"(Trejos 23).

Work at CUNA is always present for members, but at this moment CUNA does not seem to earn enough profits to distribute money back to members, and members must actually pay dues of 2 mil colones per week. I did not find out how CUNA distributes its profits to members, or if it currently does so; this is a research question that remains to be more fully answered. However, payments to members were not listed on the cooperative's yearly "flujo de caja", or sheet detailing earnings and disbursements ("Flujo de Caja", 2012). Although they have had fewer tourists as of yet, homestay families through CUNA receive similar pay to those with the Eco-Finca, listed on CUNA's plan of "Hospedaje y alimentación" as 10 mil colones per guest per day for lodging and meals. Currently this is a time of investment for CUNA's members, to build the cooperative up and hopefully earn larger profits in the future.

Environmentally, the Eco-Finca and CUNA have a very positive community impact by encouraging the practice of organic agriculture and the preservation of nature. Evangelina Sanchez, who has worked with Eco-Finca for a long time, stated that it works in harmony with nature, without contamination, and protects animals, plants, and trees that provide oxygen (personal communication, June 23, 2013). This protection of the environment relates to Koens' descriptions of "awareness raising" and "environmental education for local people as well as tourists"(Koens 1230). This is very different from the widespread chemical pollution on commercial banana and pineapple plantations surrounding the community. Medicinal plants are grown at both the Eco-Finca and CUNA; Don Julio said it is important for *campesinos* (country people) to learn how to use natural medicine, and that the only perfect technology is a natural rainforest (J. Quirós, personal communication, June 22, 2013). Negative environmental impacts of the associations or of tourism itself seem very small-scale, but families burn their garbage in pits and there is no recycling facility.

A beneficial social impact of tourism is the element of intercultural exchange. Guisselle Mora, who is married with one son, said she loves feeding and taking care of people in her home, as well as opportunities to share two different cultures (Costa Rican culture, and the visitor's culture), and to talk about life. This opportunity for dialogue relates to a comment about ASCOMAFOR in the Koens article: "Tourism with ASCOMAFOR integrates local education and culture in the tourist experience and stimulates intercultural exchanges"(Koens 1232). Mora says she's discovered that people from different places often have similar values, for instance valuing family.

While making tamales with members of CUNA, I spoke with three other homestay hosts, all single women who live alone. All agreed that life does change with tourists in the house, but

each woman highlighted different changes. Norma Sandí emphasized practical changes: having to prepare regular meals (whereas sometimes on her own she might skip a meal, or just eat leftovers), and having to organize things more when planning to leave the house for awhile, so the tourists are all right on their own (personal communication, June 22, 2013). Zaida Rivera said she especially likes the companionship provided by visitors, and that she cooks more since she isn't alone (personal communication, June 22, 2013). Evangelina Sanchez said she is happier and more content when tourists are there so she isn't by herself in the house, and that it is good to have people from other countries come to stay in the countryside because typically they would go to a beach or a hotel instead. She also said it was helpful to have work that brought in some extra money (personal communication, June 22, 2013).

One potentially problematic social impact of homestay tourism is the lack of family privacy. Family members must sometimes crowd together into one bedroom in order to empty a room for a visitor, and often there is one shared bathroom for everyone (J. Quirós, personal communication, June 22, 2013). At a recent meeting in Guápiles with the Instituto Mixto de Ayuda Social (IMAS), a few households in Santa Rosa and Cartagena received grants to have separate tourist habitations (each the size of a bedroom, with a private bathroom) built adjacent to the family's house. This will allow the host family and the tourist each more privacy, while the tourist can still be a part of home life by eating meals and visiting with the family. However, in order to receive ICT (Instituto Costarricense de Turismo) certification, each homestay household must have three tourist habitations, and at this point IMAS is providing only one per household (A. Quirós and S. Quirós, personal communication, June 25, 2013).

Otilia Aguero said that tourism is very good for local women because, in addition to employment, it provides the opportunity to learn new things (personal communication, June 23,

2013). An educational benefit of tourism in Santa Rosa and Cartagena is that tourists who are native English speakers sometimes provide English classes, if they are staying for a month or more. For example, our group taught three weeks of classes, including grades 1-6 in the Santa Rosa and Cartagena schools, and an evening class in the community salon, which was open to adults but ended up including almost entirely children as well. We covered topics including basic greetings, the formation of questions and answers, numbers, weekdays and months, the present and present progressive tenses, and telling time. As well as increasing community members' knowledge of English, our classes brought community members together for an experience of fun, enthusiasm, and companionship, a particularly unique opportunity since there are few organized activities for youth in Santa Rosa. We were also available to practice English with our host family members.

In conclusion, some of the most meaningful impacts of homestay tourism for the residents of Santa Rosa and Cartagena seemed to be additional income for individual host families, companionship and cultural exchange with the family and with the wider community, and English language instruction. The homestay experience in Santa Rosa and Cartagena correlates nicely with two of Koens' final recommendations for ecotourism as a development strategy: "…local entrepreneurship in the tourism industry should be high, and local culture should be integrated in tourists' activities"(Koens 1235). Tourist habitations provided by IMAS will help ensure greater privacy for the family and visitors, and if their number is expanded to three per household, may lead to ICT certification and a wider tourist audience.

Part C: Recommendations

The two most significant women's needs made clear to me were employment and access to education.

It is certainly important for Santa Rosa and Cartagena to continue supporting their youth who are attending high school and university. But an informal community school, aimed at a mutual sharing of knowledge and skills, would be an excellent way to share unofficial education within Santa Rosa; it requires no new infrastructure or funding and could begin right away. Don Julio brought up the idea of having a community school as part of CUNA's Finca Integral, where community members could share their skills and capacities (J. Quirós, personal communication, June 11, 2013).

At a general meeting in the salon, interested people could describe the skills and sets of knowledge they possess, as well as things they would like to learn. Then pairs could be matched between someone wanting to learn a skill and someone willing to act as a teacher. A shared skill could be something as essential as literacy; making sure everyone who wants to can learn to read and write. Other skills to share could be organic agricultural methods, sewing and craftsmanship, computer technology, spoken English, cooking and household skills, or knowledge of academic subjects by those who have attended higher education; these people could tutor elementary or high school students to help them succeed. If a group from the community school were interested in taking a course or attending a meeting located in another town, they could arrange transportation together or share rides. The school could also share books, periodicals, and Internet access. A community school would be an opportunity for inter-generational solidarity, and would empower community members by valuing the different skills they possess, similar to the ideas of asset mapping and of identifying human and social capital (Emery, Fey and Flora).

The issue of creating employment is difficult to address directly. I think the community should continue to be supportive of CUNA as it works to become more established and to develop markets for its products, because it appears to have a potential to be a sustainable source of employment in the future. Another idea, for which support was raised in interviews with three women in the community (A. Quirós, G. Mora and E. Sanchez, personal communication, June 2013), is the development of a women's artisan cooperative. Don Julio agreed this would be a good idea to develop along with CUNA in order to provide a diversity of industries, so productivity is not dependent on agriculture alone (J. Quirós, personal communication, June 24, 2013). Crafts could include clothing and accessories, paintings or fabric paintings, jewelry, or herbal soaps and shampoos. Adriana mentioned that seven or eight other women in Santa Rosa already know how to sew, including baby clothes, aprons, and underclothing. Besides being a skilled seamstress, she herself knows how to do several types of crafts, including fabric painting, foam murals for walls, and *el jarron*, a craft similar to papier-maché that can be used to make vases. She mentioned that a difficulty in setting such a cooperative up would be marketing, since Santa Rosa is a small place and opportunities would be needed to sell things in other places (A. Quirós, personal communication, June 24, 2013). Interviewees suggested that the governmental Instituto Nacional de Aprendizaje (INA) could come to the community to help train women in artisan skills, but a building may be required in order for INA to do so. Because of the interest and skills already present in the community, I think the development of a women's artisan cooperative is a worthwhile idea, notwithstanding difficulties, and it would be useful to start by finding out INA's requirements to come and give training.

A possible model to look at in building this type of project is the Cooperativa de Artesanas de Santa Elena y Monteverde, or CASEM COOP, located in Monteverde and

consisting of a store, gallery and workshop space. It was established in 1982 by eight women artists, "with the goal of using their creative skills to improve the lives of their families," and currently has almost 100 members. Listed objectives of CASEM are "…to offer employment opportunities to local women and to provide training in production and diversification of arts and crafts techniques," as well as to "promote the understanding of business operations in order to help generate extra family income and, more importantly, build self-esteem and encourage community participation" (MonteverdeInfo, 2002-2011). Members receive 65% of the sales price of all products, while the rest is invested back into the co-op, including the financing of "artistic and business management training, as well as workshops in confidence building, problem solving and conflict resolution". Its crafts include clothing, cards, jewelry, wall hangings and woodwork. Each year it works with visiting volunteer groups from Europe and the United States (MonteverdeInfo, 2002-2011).

Santa Rosa, because of its rural location and smaller-scale tourism, would need to put additional effort into finding markets for its artisan products, and in transporting products to market. A simple way to begin this marketing would be for members to work with friends and family who are originally from Santa Rosa but have moved to other places, and can seek out people they know who are interested in buying sewing or handmade crafts. This could be done through online networking, with a website and Facebook page (bilingual in Spanish and English would be ideal; a high school or university student could help translate and set up such a page), as well as seeking out partnerships with cooperatives that are currently operating in larger cities and perhaps could include crafts from Santa Rosa in their stores.

In order to set up a women's artisan cooperative, as well as to continue to sustain the Eco-Finca and CUNA, community members will need to be proactive in seeking outside grants

and other aid. When combined with community energy and innovation, outside aid can be a great help. Interviewees mentioned two government institutions from which aid can be sought: IMAS (Instituto Mixto de Ayuda Social, which just granted local homestay households aid to construct a separate tourist habitation for each house, and invited Adriana to sell her sewing at a fair in Guápiles in August), and INA (Instituto Nacional de Aprendizaje, which could train women in craftsmanship for an artisan cooperative). Continuing to network nationally and internationally (such as the Eco-Finca's partnership with MSU) to build connections may help open doors, as well as making Santa Rosa and its associations more widely known. Networking can also be done online through the creation of a website, Facebook page or LinkedIn profile. This networking relates to Bernardo Trejos' finding that "…external alliances may help community-based projects strengthen skills and political influences, as well as develop internationally accepted standards and effective marketing"(Trejos 16).

If the Eco-Finca is to be sustained, I believe it needs to accomplish two things: first, to turn its leadership and decision-making primarily over to a board of local residents, for greater community control and authentic community connection. Community members raised the issue of Lidiethe's being an outsider and often absent (J. Quirós and G. Mora, personal communication, June 23, 2013). However, she and ANDAR can still act as important resources for networking, capacity building, advice and support. Secondly, because tourists are not always present, the Eco-Finca must develop the ability to sustain itself without relying entirely on income from tourism. It could possibly achieve this by planting a greater variety of crops and developing markets for additional products; also, using a tractor or plow would be much more efficient than digging by hand as is currently done.

CUNA and the Eco-Finca are poised to offer a unique kind of tourism to educate people who are very interested in organic agriculture; this audience could include farmers, students and scientists. Because of this opportunity for agricultural education, I think both CUNA and the Eco-Finca could seek out partnerships with Costa Rica's EARTH University to bring in students. EARTH is a private, nonprofit, international university located in Guácimo, and offers an undergraduate program in agricultural sciences and natural resource management. EARTH has a Community Development Program that "includes a service-learning course where all students work with small-scale, local producers on their farms and with organized groups to promote sustainable community development"("Community Development Program"), and is aimed at connecting the university with surrounding communities. Its second campus EARTH-LaFlor, a research hub in Guanacaste, "offers seminars and training programs open to the public in areas such as renewable energies, entrepreneurship and sustainable agriculture"("EARTH Facts").

One interesting community need mentioned was a union, or unity, between all the various committees, in order to work well together (O. Aguero, personal communication, June 23, 2013). In my home community, there is a monthly women's gathering, a potluck meal which members take turns hosting at their homes. It's an excellent chance to have dialogue, meet new people, and enjoy companionship. If Santa Rosa were to organize such gatherings, perhaps in the communal salon, it might help build connections among women from the different associations and build a greater awareness of everything going on in the community. As well, it would be an opportunity simply to visit and talk with friends, providing camaraderie and support for women who may find it difficult living alone. And if domestic violence is indeed prevalent in Santa Rosa, such support networks could be crucial in order for friends to recognize the situation and help intervene.

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